

How to Talk to Your Employer About Rheumatoid Arthritis at Work

Practical NHS-backed advice on how to talk to employer about rheumatoid arthritis at work.

By **Living With Arthritis** · Reviewed by **Louis Maxwell** (HCPC Registered Physiotherapist) · 2026-07-24 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

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Quick Answer: You are not legally required to disclose rheumatoid arthritis to your employer, but doing so enables you to request reasonable adjustments under the Equality Act 2010. The best approach is a private, prepared conversation with your line manager or HR, focused on practical adjustments rather than medical detail.

RA is a disability under the Equality Act 2010 if it has a substantial, long-term effect on your daily activities — meaning your employer has a legal duty to make reasonable adjustments once they are aware.

Preparing for the Conversation

Before speaking to your manager, prepare a clear, practical list of adjustments that would help you work effectively. Focus on what you need, not medical details. Your employer doesn't need a full medical history — they need to understand practical requirements.

Reasonable Adjustments to Consider

- Flexible start times to accommodate morning stiffness

- Working from home on difficult days
 - Ergonomic equipment (keyboard, chair, mouse)
 - Permission to take short breaks to move and stretch
 - Time off for medical appointments without using annual leave
 - Adjusting workload during flares
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Your Legal Rights



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Under the Equality Act 2010, your employer cannot dismiss you or treat you less favourably because of your RA. If your employer refuses reasonable adjustments, contact ACAS (0300 123 1100) for free, confidential advice.

Q&A;

Question: Can my employer dismiss me because of RA? **Short answer:** Not legally. RA is a protected characteristic under the Equality Act 2010. Contact ACAS or an employment solicitor immediately if threatened with dismissal related to your condition.

Question: What if my manager doesn't understand RA? **Short answer:** Offer a brief written summary of how RA affects your work. NRAS has free workplace resources you can share with your employer.

Question: Do I have to disclose a new RA diagnosis? **Short answer:** No — disclosure is always your choice. However, without disclosure your employer has less legal obligation to support you or make adjustments.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk